

Onward!

Creative Careers in Animation, Computer Graphics, and Interactive Techniques

Johannes Deyoung

School of Art, Carnegie Mellon University, Pittsburgh, PA,
USA,
jsdeyoung@cmu.edu

Sara McConnell

Powerhouse Animation, Austin, TX, USA
saralynnmcconnell@gmail.com

Alex Thayer

Google Research, San Francisco, CA, USA
huevos@uw.edu

Olubunmi Mia Olufemi

Fred Rogers Company, Pittsburgh, PA, USA
olufemi@fredrogers.org

ABSTRACT

Industry panelists share perspectives and insights for students and educators who are considering careers in computer graphics and interactive techniques. Creative industries have transformed as a result of the global pandemic. Transformed workplace cultures and new technologies make room for alternative and dehabituated career paths, presenting a variety of opportunities and unforeseen challenges. Individual representatives discuss the general and specific state of affairs within their own industries, and provide insight into changing employment paradigms. Discussion includes advice for educators to help prepare students for changing workplace paradigms, as well as the preparation, training, and personal attributes students need to enter related career fields. Panelists consider what qualities make for desirable entry-level applicants in their respective fields, and elaborate upon changes in the transition from school to work resulting from the global pandemic. Represented industry segments include animation, big-data, interactive design, and game media. Questions considered include how pedagogy can help prepare and empower students for successful creative careers; what entry-level applicants should have (and should not have) on resumes, portfolios, and demo reels; and what can students do on their own to proactively acquire requisite credentials. Discussion will expose fresh outlooks on the futures of creative fields in computer graphics and interactive techniques.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Applied computing** → Arts and Humanities; Media Arts; Arts and humanities; Fine arts; Education; • **General and reference** → Cross-computing tools and techniques; Cross-computing tools and techniques; Design; Cross-computing tools and techniques; Experimentation; • **Social and professional topics** → Professional topics; Computing profession.

KEYWORDS

Education, Creative Careers, Entry-level Employment, Demo Reels

Permission to make digital or hard copies of part or all of this work for personal or classroom use is granted without fee provided that copies are not made or distributed for profit or commercial advantage and that copies bear this notice and the full citation on the first page. Copyrights for third-party components of this work must be honored. For all other uses, contact the owner/author(s).

SIGGRAPH '22 Educator's Forum, August 07–11, 2022, Vancouver, BC, Canada

© 2022 Copyright held by the owner/author(s).

ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9366-9/22/08.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3532724.3535612>

ACM Reference Format:

Johannes Deyoung, Alex Thayer, Sara McConnell, and Olubunmi Mia Olufemi. 2022. Onward!: Creative Careers in Animation, Computer Graphics, and Interactive Techniques. In *Special Interest Group on Computer Graphics and Interactive Techniques Conference Educator's Forum (SIGGRAPH '22 Educator's Forum)*, August 07–11, 2022, Vancouver, BC, Canada. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 2 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3532724.3535612>

1 PANELISTS

Johannes DeYoung (moderator) is an artist and educator who works at the intersection of computational and material processes. He is appointed Assistant Professor of Electronic and Time-Based Media at Carnegie Mellon University School of Art in Pittsburgh, PA. His work has been exhibited internationally in major galleries and museums in countries such as Spain, Taiwan, Germany, USA, Canada, Ireland, and Australia, as well as being featured in *The New York Times*, *The New York Post*, *The Huffington Post*, and *Dossier Journal*. He has lectured on his work at institutions and venues such as Yale University School of Art; Pennsylvania Academy of Fine Arts; Tyler School of Art at Temple University; Landmark Arts Gallery at Texas Tech University School of Art; Lyme Academy College of Fine Arts; the Society for Animation Studies; MODE Summit; the IEEE Games, Entertainment, and Media conference; CINAN-IMA International Animated Film Festival; and the University Film and Video Association. From 2008–2018, he taught animation and moving-image courses at Yale University School of Art, where he was appointed Senior Critic and founding Director of the Center for Collaborative Arts and Media; and at the Yale School of Drama, where he was appointed Lecturer in Design. He received his MFA from the Cranbrook Academy of Art in Bloomfield Hills, MI.

Alex Thayer, PhD is a researcher at Google and an Affiliate Assistant Professor in the Human Centered Design & Engineering department at the University of Washington. Prior to joining Google, Alex was the Head of Research for Amazon (Search) and the Chief Experience Architect for HP Labs. Alex's professional work focuses on explorations of the social-technical gap and how we make sense of people's habits, practices, and messy lives. His academic work spans topics that include multimodal interaction and education, professional collaboration and relationship work, and digital gaming. He has published 10 patents on haptic feedback systems, immersive displays, and wearable technology. He also co-leads his daughter's Girl Scout troop.

Sara McConnell is Director of Talent Acquisition at Powerhouse Animation Studios. She previously served as part of the talent

acquisition team for Netflix animation, and before that she was Director of People Operations at Powerhouse Animation Studios. She is a founding board member of Women in Animation for the Austin, TX Chapter. She is passionate about creating diversity and equity in the animation industry and focuses on disrupting biases, particularly in the editorial and post-production worlds.

Olubunmi Mia Olufemi is Supervising Producer of *Alma's Way*, the new PBS KIDS series created by Sonia Manzano and produced by Fred Rogers Productions. Mia is responsible for overseeing all phases of production, serving as the company's liaison with the animation studio and broadcaster. Mia started her career in children's television at WGBH (now known as GBH) Educational Foundation, where she worked on acclaimed children's properties including *Arthur*, *Curious George*, *Martha Speaks*, and *Design Squad*. Most

recently, she was the producer of *Molly of Denali*, the Peabody Award-winning PBS KIDS show. Her work is devoted to building inclusive productions, on screen and behind the scenes, that authentically celebrate and highlight underrepresented populations, particularly minorities and immigrant cultures. Mia received her M.A. in Writing, Literature, and Publishing from Emerson College.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

The panel is offered under the auspices of the SIGGRAPH Education Committee (Glenn Goldman, Chair and Monica Cappiello, Education Liaison). Panelists participate at the courtesy of Google (Thayer), Powerhouse Animation Studios (McConnell), Fred Rogers Productions (Olufemi), and Carnegie Mellon University (DeYoung).